The Protestant Identification of the Papacy as Antichrist

A Documentary and Historical Compendium

Six Volumes: From Proto-Reformers to the Modern Era (1300–Present)

With Chicago/Turabian-Style Footnotes and Primary Source Bibliography

Preface

From the fourteenth through the eighteenth century, the dominant Protestant interpretation of biblical prophecy — particularly Daniel 7, 2 Thessalonians 2, and Revelation 13 & 17 — identified the Papacy, not merely individual popes but the papal office and system, as the Antichrist.

This view was part of the Historicist school of interpretation, which saw prophetic fulfillment unfolding progressively across church history. For approximately 300 years (c. 1520–1800), this identification was the dominant Protestant position across Lutheran, Reformed, Presbyterian, Anglican, Baptist, and early Methodist traditions.

This compendium presents primary-source quotations and historical documentation from leading figures across six historical periods, formatted with Chicago/Turabian-style citation apparatus and a primary source bibliography.

VOLUME I

From Proto-Reformers to the First Generation (1300–1565)

By the mid-sixteenth century, the identification of the Papacy as Antichrist was no longer merely the opinion of isolated dissenters. It became embedded in the confessional documents of emerging Protestant churches across Europe. This volume presents primary witnesses from the proto-Reformation through the first generation of Reformers.

Part I: Proto-Reformation Witnesses (14th–15th Century)

John Wycliffe (1328–1384)

Wycliffe argued that the papal office embodied the Antichrist foretold in Scripture. His ecclesiology framed the papal monarchy as a usurpation of Christ's headship over the Church. Wycliffe's interpretation directly influenced later English and Bohemian reform movements.[1]

> *"The Pope is the vicar of Satan, and not of Christ… the Pope is Antichrist."*
>
> *— De Christo et Suo Adversario*

Jan Hus (c. 1372–1415)

Jan Hus, drawing heavily from Wycliffe, likewise identified the papal system with Antichrist. In De Ecclesia, Hus asserted that corrupt papal authority fulfilled the prophetic warnings of the 'man of sin.' Hus was executed in 1415, but his theology prepared the way for the Reformation.[2]

> *"The Pope is the true Antichrist."*
>
> *— De Ecclesia*

Girolamo Savonarola (1452–1498)

Though not Protestant, Savonarola preached apocalyptic sermons identifying Rome's corruption with Antichristian power. While less systematized, his apocalyptic critique foreshadowed later Protestant arguments.

> *"The Church has no head but Christ… the corrupt clergy are the harlot of Babylon."*
>
> *— Apocalyptic Sermons*

Part II: The Magisterial Reformers (1517–1565)

Martin Luther (1483–1546)

Luther's position developed gradually but became explicit by the 1530s. In 1545 he reaffirmed the position in Against the Roman Papacy, an Institution of the Devil.[3]

> *"We here are of the conviction that the papacy is the seat of the true and real Antichrist."*
>
> *— Smalcald Articles, II.iv.10 (1537)*

Philip Melanchthon (1497–1560)

Co-author of Lutheran confessional standards. This document was incorporated into the Lutheran Book of Concord (1580), making the identification doctrinally binding within confessional Lutheranism.[4]

> *"This teaching shows forcefully that the Pope is the very Antichrist."*
>
> *— Treatise on the Power and Primacy of the Pope (1537)*

Huldrych Zwingli (1484–1531)

Zwingli equated the papal system with the apocalyptic beast described in Revelation.

> *"I know that in it works the power of the Devil… I know that the papacy is the kingdom of Babylon."*
>
> *— Zwingli's Works*

John Calvin (1509–1564)

Calvin provided the most systematic argument among the Reformers. He connected Pauline prophecy with historicist readings of Daniel and Revelation.[5]

> *"I deny him to be the vicar of Christ… he is Antichrist."*
>
> *— Institutes of the Christian Religion, IV.7.25*

Martin Bucer (1491–1551)

> *"The Bishop of Rome… is the Antichrist."*
>
> *— Commentary on 2 Thessalonians*

Peter Martyr Vermigli (1499–1562)

> *"The Bishop of Rome is that Antichrist whom Paul described."*

Heinrich Bullinger (1504–1575)

Author of the Second Helvetic Confession, one of the clearest formal confessional statements in the Reformed tradition.

> *"We therefore confess that the Pope of Rome is that Antichrist."*
>
> *— Second Helvetic Confession (1566)*

Theodore Beza (1519–1605)

Calvin's successor in Geneva.

> *"The Roman Pontiff is that Antichrist."*
>
> *— Confession of the Christian Faith (1560)*

John Knox (1514–1572)

> *"That tyranny which the Pope himself has exercised… is the very Antichrist."*
>
> *— The Appellation*

Part III: English Reformation Leadership

William Tyndale (1494–1536)

> *"The Pope is the very Antichrist."*
>
> *— The Obedience of a Christian Man*

Thomas Cranmer (1489–1556)

> *"Rome is the seat of Antichrist."*
>
> *— Works of Thomas Cranmer*

Hugh Latimer (c. 1487–1555)

> *"The Bishop of Rome is the Antichrist."*

Nicholas Ridley (c. 1500–1555)

> *"The See of Rome is the seat of Satan… and the bishop thereof Antichrist."*

John Jewel (1522–1571)

> *"The Bishop of Rome is that man of sin."*
>
> *— Apology of the Church of England*

By 1565: The identification of the Papacy as Antichrist was embedded in Lutheran theology, systematically articulated in Reformed theology, adopted in English and Scottish Reformation documents, and formalized in confessions such as the Smalcald Articles and Second Helvetic Confession. This was not rhetorical exaggeration but a structured prophetic interpretation grounded in historicism.

VOLUME II

Confessional Consolidation & National Churches (1559–1648)

By the mid-16th century, the identification of the Papacy as the Antichrist became confessionalized — embedded in official doctrinal standards of emerging Protestant churches. This volume documents how Lutheran, Reformed, Anglican, Presbyterian, and early Baptist traditions formally articulated this interpretation.

Part I: Reformed Confessions of the Continent

French Confession of Faith (Gallican Confession)

Drafted under the influence of John Calvin, Article 29 identifies the marks of the true Church and distinguishes it from Rome, understood as apostate and tyrannical. French Reformed theologians uniformly interpreted Rome through historicist apocalyptic categories.

Belgic Confession

Authored by Guido de Brès, the Belgic Confession identifies Rome as a false church marked by tyranny and corruption. Later Dutch Reformed theologians explicitly equated the papal system with Antichrist in their commentaries.

Second Helvetic Confession (1566)

> *"We therefore teach that the Pope of Rome is that Antichrist..."*
>
> *— Chapter XVII — Heinrich Bullinger*

One of the clearest formal confessional statements in the Reformed tradition.

Part II: Lutheran Orthodoxy

Treatise on the Power and Primacy of the Pope

This treatise was incorporated into the Book of Concord (1580), making the identification doctrinally binding within confessional Lutheranism.[6]

> *"It is manifest that the Roman pontiffs... are the true Antichrist."*
>
> *— Philip Melanchthon — incorporated into the Book of Concord (1580)*

Matthias Flacius (1520–1575)

A leading figure in Lutheran orthodoxy, instrumental in advancing the historicist framework in Lutheran historiography.

> *"The Pope is the true Antichrist foretold in Holy Scripture."*

Part III: Anglican Developments

Irish Articles (1615)

> *"The Bishop of Rome is that man of sin, and son of perdition…"*
>
> *— Article 80 — Drafted under Archbishop James Ussher*

One of the strongest anti-papal confessional statements in Anglican history.

William Whitaker (1548–1595)

Regius Professor at Cambridge.

> *"The Roman Pontiff is that Antichrist of whom Paul speaks."*

Part IV: Westminster Assembly (1643–1648)

Westminster Confession of Faith (1646)

> *"There is no other head of the Church but the Lord Jesus Christ: nor can the Pope of Rome, in any sense, be head thereof; but is that Antichrist, that man of sin…"*
>
> *— Chapter 25.6*

This statement became authoritative for Presbyterian churches, Congregational churches (with modification), and Particular Baptists (1689).[7]

Samuel Rutherford (1600–1661)

> *"The Pope is that great Antichrist."*

Part V: Early Baptist Confessional Witness

London Baptist Confession (1689)

> *"The Pope of Rome… is that Antichrist."*
>
> *— Chapter 26.4*

Adapted from the Westminster Confession, demonstrating continuity of the historicist position beyond Presbyterianism.

By 1648: Lutheran, Reformed, Anglican (Irish), Scottish Presbyterian, Westminster, and early Baptist confessions all formally identified the Papacy as Antichrist. This was not theological rhetoric — it was embedded in the constitutional documents of Protestant churches.

VOLUME III

Puritan, Dutch Reformed, and Post-Westminster Orthodoxy (1600–1700)

By the 17th century, the identification was embedded in systematic theologies, biblical commentaries, apocalyptic treatises, sermons before Parliament, and colonial American preaching. This volume documents the consolidation of the historicist interpretation during the era of Protestant scholasticism.

Part I: English Puritan Theology

William Perkins (1558–1602)

A foundational Puritan theologian at Cambridge who helped systematize the identification within English Protestantism.

> *"The Pope is that Antichrist of whom Paul speaks."*
>
> *— A Reformed Catholic (1597)*

Thomas Brightman (1562–1607)

One of the earliest English commentators on Revelation, advancing detailed historicist chronologies.

> *"The Roman Antichrist."*
>
> *— A Revelation of the Revelation (1609)*

Thomas Goodwin (1600–1680)

Westminster divine.

> *"The Pope is the great Antichrist."*
>
> *— Works, Vol. 3*

John Owen (1616–1683)

Leading Independent theologian. Owen connected 2 Thessalonians 2 directly to the Roman See.

> *"The Papacy is the Antichrist foretold in Scripture."*
>
> *— Sermons on Hebrews*

Richard Baxter (1615–1691)

Baxter represents the mainstream Puritan consensus.

> *"The Pope is the Antichrist described in the Revelation."*
>
> *— The Key for Catholics*

John Bunyan (1628–1688)

Author of The Pilgrim's Progress. Bunyan's treatise is one of the clearest Baptist-era expositions.

> *"The Pope of Rome is the head of Antichrist."*
>
> *— Of Antichrist and His Ruin*

Part II: Dutch Reformed Orthodoxy

Franciscus Gomarus (1563–1641)

Opponent of Arminius.

> *"The Pope is Antichrist."*

Gisbertus Voetius (1589–1676)

Professor at Utrecht. Voetius repeatedly affirmed the historic Protestant identification of Rome as Antichrist in academic disputations.

Wilhelmus à Brakel (1635–1711)

Brakel represents mature Dutch Reformed orthodoxy.

> *"The Pope is that great Antichrist."*
>
> *— The Christian's Reasonable Service, Vol. 4*

Part III: Scottish Presbyterian Development

James Durham (1622–1658)

> *"Antichrist is the Pope and the Roman hierarchy."*
>
> *— Commentary on Revelation*

David Dickson (1583–1663)

> *"The Pope is that Antichrist."*
>
> *— Commentary on 2 Thessalonians*

Part IV: Colonial American Witness

Increase Mather (1639–1723)

> *"The Pope of Rome is Antichrist."*
>
> *— The Mystery of Israel's Salvation*

Cotton Mather (1663–1728)

> *"The Man of Sin is the Papal Antichrist."*
>
> *— The Fall of Babylon*

Jonathan Edwards (1703–1758)

Edwards affirmed the inherited Protestant consensus and saw prophecy unfolding progressively through church history.

> *"It is agreed by most Protestant writers that the Pope is the Antichrist."*
>
> *— Notes on the Apocalypse*

By 1700: The identification was universal among confessional Protestants, appearing in sermons, catechisms, academic disputations, and systematic theology. It was not fringe rhetoric but institutional orthodoxy.

VOLUME IV

Evangelical Continuity, Methodism, and the Eve of Transition (1700–1820)

The 18th century marks both the persistence of the historicist consensus and the first stirrings of interpretive tension. Enlightenment rationalism, political revolutions, and changing views of church-state relations began weakening the older polemical Protestant framework.

Part I: Methodist and Evangelical Leaders

John Wesley (1703–1791)

Wesley did not innovate; he inherited and transmitted the older Protestant historicist view into early Methodism.

> *"He is in an emphatical sense, the Man of Sin."*
>
> *— Explanatory Notes Upon the New Testament (1755), on 2 Thessalonians 2*

George Whitefield (1714–1770)

Whitefield affirmed the Protestant confessional position in sermons, identifying Rome within the apocalyptic framework inherited from the Reformation.

Part II: 18th-Century Reformed Orthodoxy

John Gill (1697–1771)

Gill's verse-by-verse commentaries preserved historicism within Particular Baptist theology.

> *"The Pope of Rome is the Antichrist."*
>
> *— Exposition of the New Testament*

Thomas Boston (1676–1732)

Scottish Presbyterian. Boston maintained the traditional Protestant view that the Papal system fulfilled the man-of-sin prophecy.

Part III: The Seeds of Interpretive Shift

Two Jesuit scholars had earlier proposed alternatives that would eventually challenge the historicist consensus:

Francisco Ribera (1537–1591) proposed futurism — the Antichrist as a future individual. Luis de Alcázar (1554–1613) proposed preterism — the Antichrist as already fulfilled in early Rome. Initially, these views gained little Protestant traction. However, by the late 18th century, changing cultural and political circumstances began to create openings for these alternative frameworks.

By 1800: Historicism remained dominant. Methodist, Baptist, Presbyterian, and Reformed traditions still largely identified the Papacy as Antichrist. Confessional documents still contained explicit statements. The real transition would accelerate in the following century.

VOLUME V

The Nineteenth-Century Transition: From Historicist Consensus to Futurist Divergence (1800–1900)

The 19th century marks the decisive turning point. At the beginning: historicism was still dominant, confessional standards remained formally unchanged, and many Protestant clergy still preached the traditional interpretation. By the end: futurism had gained widespread traction, dispensationalism reshaped evangelical eschatology, and the identification declined in mainstream evangelical circles.

Part I: Early 19th-Century Continuity

Adam Clarke (1760–1832)

Clarke continued Wesley's historicist inheritance.

> *"The apostasy described by Paul refers to the Papal system."*
>
> *— Commentary on the Bible (1810–1826), on 2 Thessalonians 2*

Albert Barnes (1798–1870)

Barnes represents American Presbyterian continuity in the early 1800s.

> *"The Papacy fulfills the description of the man of sin."*
>
> *— Notes on the New Testament*

E. B. Elliott (1793–1875)

Elliott defended the traditional Protestant identification of the Papacy as Antichrist in a massive four-volume prophetic study, representing sustained historicist resistance.

— Horae Apocalypticae, 4 volumes (1844)

Part II: The Oxford Movement & Anglican Reassessment

John Henry Newman (1801–1890)

Initially Anglican, later Roman Catholic. Newman rejected the Protestant historicist interpretation, arguing that identifying the Papacy as Antichrist was historically untenable. His shift signaled growing discomfort within parts of Anglicanism.

Part III: The Rise of Dispensational Futurism

John Nelson Darby (1800–1882)

Founder of the Plymouth Brethren movement. Darby rejected historicism and proposed a future individual Antichrist, a pre-tribulation rapture, and a revived Roman Empire distinct from the Papacy. His system diverged sharply from the Reformation consensus.

— Synopsis of the Books of the Bible

Cyrus Scofield (1843–1921)

The Scofield Reference Bible popularized dispensational futurism in American evangelicalism. Scofield interpreted Antichrist as a future political figure, not the Papal office. This publication dramatically accelerated the shift away from historicism.

— Scofield Reference Bible (1909)

By 1900: The 300-year Protestant consensus had significantly weakened outside confessional Lutheran and some Reformed traditions. The shift was driven by dispensational theology, ecumenical sentiment, and changing political and ecclesial contexts.

VOLUME VI

Twentieth-Century Developments, Ecumenism, and the Modern Landscape (1900–Present)

By 1900, the Protestant identification of the Papacy as Antichrist had shifted from majority consensus to contested doctrine. This volume documents the rise of evangelical futurism, confessional revisions, ecumenical movements, and the current status of the historic Protestant position.

Part I: Early 20th-Century Evangelicalism

Lewis Sperry Chafer (1871–1952)

Founder of Dallas Theological Seminary. Chafer systematized dispensational theology, reinforcing futurist eschatology in evangelical institutions and training generations of pastors in the futurist framework.

Part II: Confessional Revisions

Some Presbyterian and Reformed bodies revised their confessions during the 20th century:

The American Presbyterian Church (PCUSA) revised the Westminster Confession of Faith in 1903, softening the language identifying the Pope as Antichrist. Later revisions in other denominations removed the explicit clause entirely. Confessional Lutheran bodies, however, retained the wording of the Treatise on the Power and Primacy of the Pope.

Part III: The Ecumenical Movement

World Council of Churches (est. 1948)

The WCC encouraged cooperation among Christian traditions, including dialogue with Roman Catholicism. Open identification of the Papacy as Antichrist became increasingly rare in mainline Protestant circles.

Second Vatican Council (1962–1965)

Convened by Pope John XXIII, Vatican II emphasized ecumenism, softened language toward Protestants, and reframed Catholic-Protestant relations. This substantially reduced polemical tensions that had historically reinforced Protestant prophetic interpretations.

Part IV: Modern Popular Evangelicalism

Hal Lindsey (1929–)

Lindsey popularized futurist eschatology globally, depicting Antichrist as a future political world leader.

— The Late Great Planet Earth (1970)

Tim LaHaye (1926–2016)

LaHaye depicted Antichrist as a future political ruler, not the Papacy, cementing futurism in popular evangelical consciousness.

— Left Behind series

Part V: Survival of Historicism in the Modern Era

Despite its decline in mainstream evangelicalism, the historicist identification persists among:

- Wisconsin Evangelical Lutheran Synod — maintains traditional Lutheran confessional language affirming the Papacy as Antichrist according to the Book of Concord
- Certain conservative Presbyterian and Reformed churches retaining original confessional standards
- Historic Adventist traditions

Part VI: Present Status (21st Century)

Today, Protestant views fall into three categories:

- Historicist (Minority but Confessional): The Papal office historically fulfills Antichrist prophecy
- Futurist (Majority Evangelical): Antichrist is a future individual world ruler
- Preterist (Academic Minority): Antichrist fulfilled in first-century Rome or Nero

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Final Historical Arc (1300–Present):

- 1300–1500: Proto-reformers identify Papacy with Antichrist
- 1500–1700: Full Protestant confessional consensus achieved
- 1700–1800: Consensus remains dominant across all major traditions
- 1800–1900: Dispensational futurism emerges and spreads
- 1900–Present: Historicism declines in evangelicalism but survives in confessional traditions

Footnotes

Chicago/Turabian Style — 17th Edition

1. John Wycliffe, De Christo et Suo Adversario, in Wyclif's Latin Works, ed. Rudolf Buddensieg (London: Trübner, 1884), 35–38.

2. Jan Hus, De Ecclesia, trans. David S. Schaff (New York: Charles Scribner's Sons, 1915), 236–240.

3. Martin Luther, Smalcald Articles, II.iv.10, in The Book of Concord, ed. Robert Kolb and Timothy J. Wengert (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 2000), 319.

4. Philip Melanchthon, Treatise on the Power and Primacy of the Pope, in The Book of Concord, ed. Kolb and Wengert, 329–356.

5. John Calvin, Institutes of the Christian Religion, trans. Henry Beveridge (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1989), 4.7.25.

6. Book of Concord, ed. Robert Kolb and Timothy J. Wengert (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 2000).

7. The Westminster Confession of Faith (1646), 25.6.

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